

The Boston Globe

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THURSDAY, DECEMBER 18, 2025

Trump, Caracas in tanker faceoff

President orders ‘blockade’; ships leave with escorts

By Edward Wong, Simon Romero, and Charlie Savage
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Trump has ordered a “complete blockade” on sanctioned oil tankers going to and from Venezuela, an escalation of his administration’s monthslong pressure campaign against Nicolás Maduro, the leader of Venezuela.

Hours after the order, Venezuela’s government ordered its navy to escort tankers from port, escalating the risk of a confrontation.

“Venezuela is completely surrounded by the largest Armada ever assembled in the History of South America,” Trump wrote on social media Tuesday, referring to Navy ships deployed to the region. “It will only get bigger, and the shock to them will be like nothing they have ever seen before.”

A blockade would hobble Venezuela’s oil exports, which are the lifeblood of the country’s economy. Venezuela relies entirely on tankers to export its oil to world markets. There were more than 30 vessels operating in Venezuela this month that had been sanctioned by the United States, according to independent tracking service Tanker Trackers.

Last week, the United States seized a tanker in the Caribbean Sea that was carrying Venezuelan oil for Cuba and China. A federal judge had issued a warrant for the seizure based on the fact that the tanker had recently transported oil from Iran.

VENEZUELA, Page A5



NEW YORK TIMES

An oil tanker plied the waters off the coast of Punto Fijo, Venezuela.

Four politically vulnerable House Republicans rebelled against their own party’s refusal to address Affordable Care Act subsidies slated to expire at the end of the year. **A2.**

The demolition of Cambridge’s Riverview condo building has begun, piece by piece. **B1.**

Deposed Market Basket chief executive Arthur T. Demoulas took the stand in a Delaware courtroom as he fights to regain his job. **D1.**



On the up and up

Thursday: Some sun, mild. High 43-48. Low 38-43,
Friday: Rain early, warm. High 55-60. Low 26-31.
Sunrise: 7:08 Sunset: 4:13
Weather and Comics, D5-6.

VOL. 308, NO. 171

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Shots, then a race for their lives

As nightmare unfolded, stunned students tried to make sense of it

By Samantha J. Gross, Sean Cotter, and Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

PROVIDENCE — Not everyone recognized the sound of gunfire.

Drew Nelson did: He grew up next to a Marine Corps base and immediately knew the sound of a firearm. Refath Bari was hearing the strange staccato pops for the first time, noting their surreal, alien quality, how quickly

each bang started and stopped.

But both men — one a freshman from California, one a master’s candidate in physics — knew they should not be hearing those sounds here, in the bowels of Brown University’s Barus & Holley engineering building, where Nelson was gathered with his baseball teammates to study for an economics exam, and Bari was leaving his office to get a snack.

It just doesn’t make sense, Nelson thought.

Nelson was in a room across the hallway when the shooting started; Bari was around the corner. Inside the classroom itself, the shots sounded like a folding desk snapping shut. Students scrambled to the lower part of the room, away from the door. Finally, silence.

SHOOTING, Page A7



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

A student stood at Brown University’s Van Wickle Gates, a landmark on the campus, where flowers have been laid this week.

In an emotional moment, misinformation sweeps into mainstream

By Anjali Huynh and Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

Days after the deadly attack at Brown University, information remains scarce about the assailant who killed two students and wounded nine on Saturday. For some, rumors, misinformation, and widespread fear are filling in the gaps.

Authorities said Tuesday evening

that they were still searching for the gunman who opened fire in a campus building, working with at least 200 “actionable tips” on the shooting. The few details they released included that he is an approximately 5 foot 8 inch male with a “stocky build” who “definitely targeted Brown.”

In the absence of a clear narrative, misinformation about the shooter and any possible motives has spread,

with a host of right-wing influencers promoting unverified theories. In some cases, they were amplified by members of Congress.

The response to the tragedy, misinformation experts said, demonstrates how the information environment has deteriorated. Some elected officials are relaying false information or suggesting unproven motives — claims that once may have re-

mained in fringe circles, not leaked into the mainstream. Meanwhile, many in the general public have less trust in institutions providing factual information, and there are few measures in place, especially online, to determine what’s real.

Acts of mass violence are “prone to this sort of rumor-spread, misinformation, where no one knows

MISINFORMATION, Page A6

Hospitals struggle to fill one of their most crucial roles

Sitters often lacking for patients at risk to selves

Editor’s note: The following story contains a description of an attempted suicide. If you or a loved one are having emotional distress or thoughts of suicide, call 988 to connect with a lifeline specialist for support.

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

A nurse was walking by a room in the emergency department of Baystate Franklin Medical Center in Greenfield in October when she saw something that made her scream for help.

A patient who had been deemed a high risk for suicide had tied a bedsheet around their neck, according to three department

nurses familiar with the incident. They insisted that no identifying details about the patient be shared because of federal privacy laws.

Several nurses raced into the room and frantically cut through the sheet with scissors. The patient was unharmed, but the episode left nurses shaken. The patient was supposed to have received constant monitoring by a staffer known as a “sitter” or “patient observer” but had been left alone.

Simple arithmetic explains why. There were four other suicidal patients in the department at the time and only one sitter on duty because of a shortage of such employ-

SITTERS, Page A10



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

“We need more people in these roles,” said Suzanne Love, a Baystate Franklin Medical Center nurse and a union leader.

As climate bill was advanced, industry donations poured in

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

In early November, state Representative Mark Cusack found himself in a difficult position.

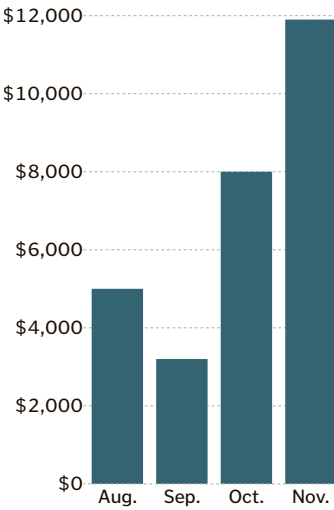
Environmental advocates were apoplectic about a climate bill the new chairman had authored that would weaken the state’s efforts to reduce emissions from fossil fuels. The energy industry had an interest in the bill, too, arguing it would help consumers and businesses facing high energy costs.

Under pressure from both sides, on Nov. 12, Cusack advanced the bill out of his committee, a major step on the path to becoming law.

That same day, he reported receiving thousands of dollars in campaign donations from utility companies, energy groups, and the lobbyists who represent them.

Overall, in November, Cusack, other members of the powerful energy committee, and House leaders raked in nearly \$12,000 from industry groups and their lobbyists — much more than what they received from the industry in any other month this fall. In November, industry donations made

Donations to members of House leadership and utilities committee



SOURCE: Massachusetts Office of Campaign and Political Finance
DAIGO FUJIWARA-SMITH/GLOBE STAFF

up 60 percent of Cusack’s campaign collections. It was a significant flex from the energy industry, which has historically been one of the top sources of funding for powerful Massachusetts Democrats.

House leaders, including Cusack and Speaker Ron Mariano, insist such contributors do not hold sway over their decisions

CLIMATE, Page A10